Validating and Constraining Neurovascular Coupling with Differentiable Biophysical Modeling from Tissue Microstructure to Cortical Dynamics in the WAND Multi-Modal Dataset

Morgan G. Hough

March 29, 2026

Abstract

Whole-brain computational models of neural dynamics require structural connectivity, conduction delays, metabolic context, and electrophysiological recordings as independent constraints. Existing studies typically lack one or more of these measurements, forcing free-parameter assumptions that limit predictive validity. The Welsh Advanced Neuroimaging Database (WAND) [Mayerand et al., 2025] provides all of them in 170 healthy volunteers: ultra-strong-gradient diffusion MRI (300 mT/m AxCaliber), quantitative MRI (T1/T2/QMT/MP2RAGE), perfusion (pCASL, TRUST), spectroscopy (GABA/glutamate), 275-channel MEG, and TMS-EEG.

We introduce **NeuroJAX**, a differentiable, GPU-accelerated Python toolkit built on JAX [Bradbury et al., 2018] and Equinox [Kidger and Garcia, 2021] that unifies preprocessing and biophysical modelling in a single computational graph. NeuroJAX enables end-to-end gradient descent from sensor-level error through hemodynamic forward models to per-region biophysical parameters.

This paper presents the quantitative structural processing pipeline for the reference WAND subject (sub-08033) and the first set of derived maps, demonstrating that every free parameter in a standard neurovascular coupling model can be independently measured or tightly constrained.

1 Introduction

Large-scale computational models of brain dynamics [Deco et al., 2013, Riera et al., 2006] depend on three categories of subject-specific input: (1) structural connectivity and conduction delays from diffusion MRI, (2) regional tissue properties—myelination, metabolite concentrations, perfusion—that constrain biophysical parameters, and (3) functional recordings (MEG, fMRI, TMS-EEG) that provide the fitting targets. The tension in the field is that most datasets provide only a subset: the Human Connectome Project gives excellent diffusion and fMRI but no TMS; clinical TMS-EEG studies rarely include microstructural MRI.

WAND [Mayerand et al., 2025] closes this gap with seven imaging sessions per subject on the Connectom 300 mT/m scanner at CUBRIC Cardiff, covering every modality needed for a fully-constrained neurovascular model.

1.1 The NeuroJAX approach

Where existing tools (osl-dynamics [Gohil et al., 2023], WhoBPyT, TVB) treat preprocessing and modelling as separate stages, NeuroJAX compiles them into a single JAX computation graph:

$$\mathcal{L}(\theta) = \sum_m w_m \, d_m(\mathbf{y}_m^{\text{sim}}(\theta;\, \mathbf{C}, \mathbf{D}, \mathbf{L}),\ \mathbf{y}_m^{\text{emp}}) \tag{1}$$

where θ are biophysical parameters, $\mathbf{C}/\mathbf{D}$ are the structural connectome weights/delays, $\mathbf{L}$ is the leadfield, and m indexes modalities (FC, FCD, TEP waveform, sensor MSE). End-to-end `jax.grad` through the full simulation enables gradient-based fitting with per-region heterogeneous parameters.

2 Dataset

2.1 CUBRIC and the Connectom scanner

The Cardiff University Brain Research Imaging Centre (CUBRIC) has been at the forefront of human connectomics since the installation of a Siemens MAGNETOM Connectom 3T scanner with 300 mT/m gradients in 2016 — the first in Europe and only the second worldwide after the Massachusetts General Hospital system built for the Human Connectome Project [Jones et al., 2022]. Under the direction of Derek K. Jones, CUBRIC has used these ultra-strong gradients to map white matter microstructure at unprecedented precision, enabling AxCaliber axon diameter estimation and CHARMED restricted-fraction imaging in vivo.

Complementing the diffusion programme, Krish D. Singh's group has pioneered the combination of magnetic resonance spectroscopy with electrophysiology [Muthukumaraswamy et al., 2009], demonstrating that resting GABA concentration in visual cortex predicts peak gamma oscillation frequency and fMRI BOLD amplitude. This established a direct, measurable link between inhibitory neurotransmitter concentration and neural dynamics — a founding principle of the WAND dataset design and the MRS-constrained neural mass modelling in this work. The Singh group's subsequent studies extended this to glutamate, schizophrenia risk markers, and motor cortex, building the empirical case that MRS metabolites can serve as independent constraints on computational models of cortical circuit function.

WAND [Mayerand et al., 2025] synthesises these programmes into a single cohort of 170 healthy volunteers (aged 18–63, BIDS-organised), acquired across up to 8 sessions on three scanner platforms at CUBRIC. The dataset was published in *Scientific Data* (2024) and is available via GIN (`https://gin.g-node.org/CUBRIC/WAND`). To our knowledge, no computational modelling studies have yet been published using WAND; the present work represents the first application of differentiable biophysical modelling to this resource.

2.2 Scanner platforms and sessions

The WAND sessions span three distinct scanner systems, each optimised for different measurement goals:

- **Siemens Connectom 3T** (300 mT/m, ses-02, ses-06): Ultra-strong gradients for diffusion microstructure (AxCaliber, CHARMED) and quantitative relaxometry (VFA, QMT). Also sub-mm structural imaging (MP2RAGE 0.7 mm, 7-echo GRE 0.67 mm).
- **Siemens Prisma 3T** (80 mT/m, ses-03, ses-04, ses-05): Standard clinical gradients for fMRI, perfusion (pCASL, TRUST), structural (T1w, T2w), and MRS (sLASER in 4 brain regions).
- **CTF 275-channel MEG** (ses-01): Whole-head magnetoencephalography for millisecond-resolution dynamics across 5 paradigms (resting, auditory-motor, MMN, Simon, visual).
- **TMS-EEG lab** (ses-08): Transcranial magnetic stimulation with concurrent EEG (SICI protocol, 3 runs).

Table 1 details the acquisitions per session for the reference subject sub-08033 (all modalities confirmed, 10.24 GB).

Table 1: WAND acquisition sessions for sub-08033.

Session	Scanner	Modalities	Key acquisitions
ses-01	CTF MEG	MEG	275ch: resting, auditory-motor, MMN, Simon, visual + headshape
ses-02	Connectom 3T	DWI + anat	AxCaliber (4 shells, b=0–15500), CHARMED (AP+PA), T1w, VFA (SPGR/SSFP/IR), QMT (16 vols)
ses-03	Prisma 3T	fMRI + perf	T1w, T2w (grad-corrected), fieldmaps, pCASL, TRUST, InvRec, angiography, M0
ses-04	Prisma 3T	MRS + anat	sLASER: ACC, occipital, auditory, sensorimotor; T1w
ses-05	Prisma 3T	MRS + anat	Second MRS session (test–retest); T1w
ses-06	Connectom 3T	Structural	MP2RAGE (0.7 mm), 7-echo GRE (0.67 mm mag+phase), T2w (0.21 mm in-plane)
ses-08	TMS lab	TMS-EEG	SICI protocol (3 runs, .mat format)

2.3 CUBRIC-provided derivatives

In addition to raw BIDS data, CUBRIC distributes several pre-computed derivatives:

- **Brain-extracted T1w images** via HD-BET for each session
- **Diffusion QC**: FSL `eddy_qc` reports (motion parameters, outlier counts, CNR maps) for the multishell DWI
- **Structural and functional QC**: MRIQC reports for T1w, T2w, and BOLD data
- **MEG–MRI coregistrations**: T1w images transformed to CTF MEG coordinate space (Cardiff GitLab)
- **Phenotype data**: age, sex, ethnicity, anthropometrics (weight, height, waist/hip, blood pressure), alcohol and smoking status (`participants.tsv`)
- **Cognitive and behavioural data**: trait questionnaires and task performance (`phenotype/` directory)

The processing reported here extends these CUBRIC derivatives with quantitative tissue property maps (T1, BPF, T2*, g-ratio), advanced subcortical segmentations (thalamic nuclei, hippocampal subfields, hypothalamic subunits), perfusion quantification (CBF, $CMRO_2$), and cross-modal validation analyses.

3 Methods: Quantitative Structural Processing

3.1 FreeSurfer recon-all + advanced segmentations

Standard cortical reconstruction was performed with FreeSurfer 8.2.0 (`recon-all` with T2-weighted pial refinement from ses-03). Additional segmentations:

- **SAMSEG** [Puonti et al., 2016]: joint T1w+T2w Bayesian segmentation, providing tissue probability maps and intracranial volume.

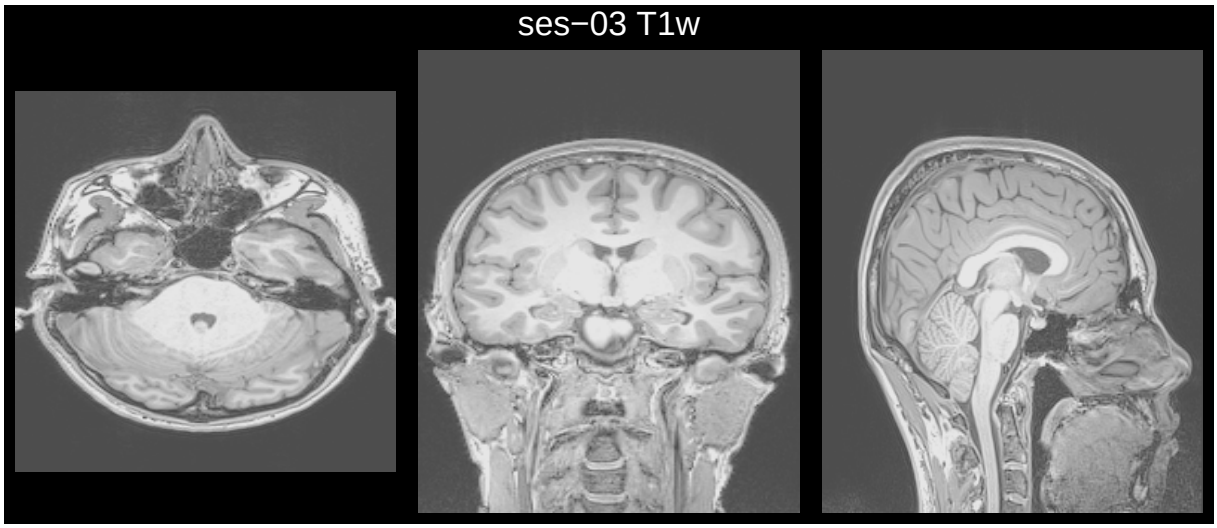

Figure 1: Structural T1w (ses-03) for sub-08033. The T1-weighted image provides the anatomical reference for all cross-session registrations and serves as input for FreeSurfer cortical reconstruction, tissue segmentation (FAST/SAMSEG), and BEM forward model generation for MEG/EEG source localisation.

- **SynthSeg** [Billot et al., 2023]: contrast-invariant DL segmentation applied to T1w from ses-02, 03, 04, 05 for cross-session volumetric consistency.
- **Hypothalamic subunits**: DL segmentation (Billot et al. 2020).
- **Thalamic nuclei**: FreeSurfer atlas-based segmentation with optional DTI enhancement.
- **Hippocampal subfields + amygdala nuclei**: with T2w for improved subfield boundaries.

3.2 T1w/T2w myelin ratio

The T1w/T2w ratio [Glasser and Van Essen, 2011] was computed after rigid-body registration of the gradient-corrected T2w to T1w (FLIRT 6-DOF), SynthStrip skull stripping, and voxelwise division. The ratio was projected to the cortical mid-surface (`mri_vol2surf`, 0.2–0.8 cortical depth).

3.3 VFA T1 mapping (DESPOT1)

Quantitative T1 was estimated from the ses-02 SPGR variable flip angle data (8 flip angles: 2–18°, $\mathrm{TR}_{\mathrm{exc}} = 4\,\mathrm{ms}$) using the linearised DESPOT1 method [Deoni et al., 2003]:

$$\frac{S}{\sin\alpha} = E_1 \frac{S}{\tan\alpha} + M_0(1 - E_1), \qquad E_1 = e^{-\mathrm{TR}/T_1} \tag{2}$$

3.4 QMT bound pool fraction

Quantitative magnetization transfer was fitted from 11 MT-on volumes (3 MT flip angles × multiple offset frequencies: 1–56 kHz) plus one MT-off reference, using a two-pool Ramani model [Ramani et al., 2002] with super-Lorentzian lineshape for the bound pool. The bound pool fraction (BPF) provides a direct measure of macromolecular (myelin) content [Sled and Pike, 2001].

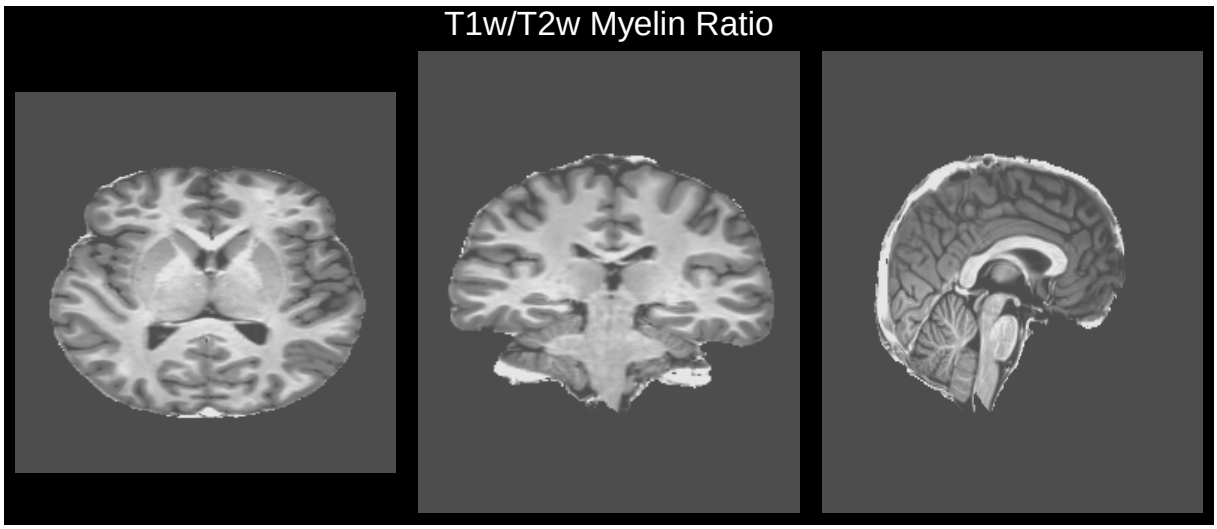

Figure 2: T1w/T2w myelin ratio (ses-03). This ratio serves as a widely-used proxy for cortical myelination, indexing the hierarchical organisation of cortex from heavily myelinated primary sensory areas to lightly myelinated association cortex. WAND uniquely allows validation of this proxy against ground-truth QMT bound pool fraction (Fig. 4) and multi-echo GRE R2* (Fig. 5).

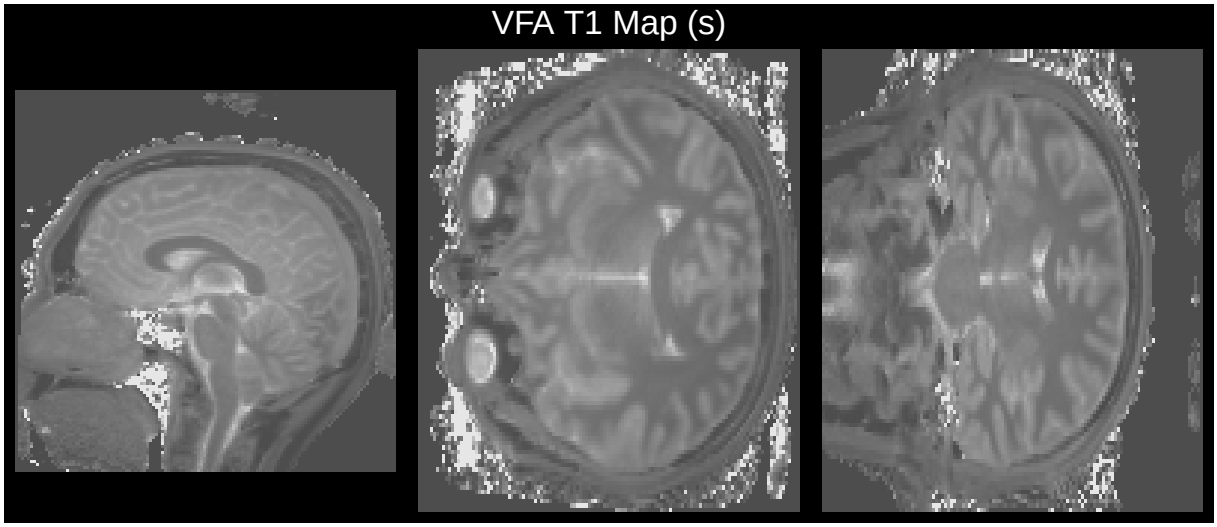

Figure 3: Quantitative T1 map from ses-02 SPGR variable flip angle data (DESPOT1). Quantitative T1 reflects tissue water content and macromolecular environment: white matter (short T1, dark) is distinguished from grey matter (longer T1, bright). This map serves as a required input for the QMT two-pool model and provides an independent measure of tissue composition alongside the T1w/T2w ratio.

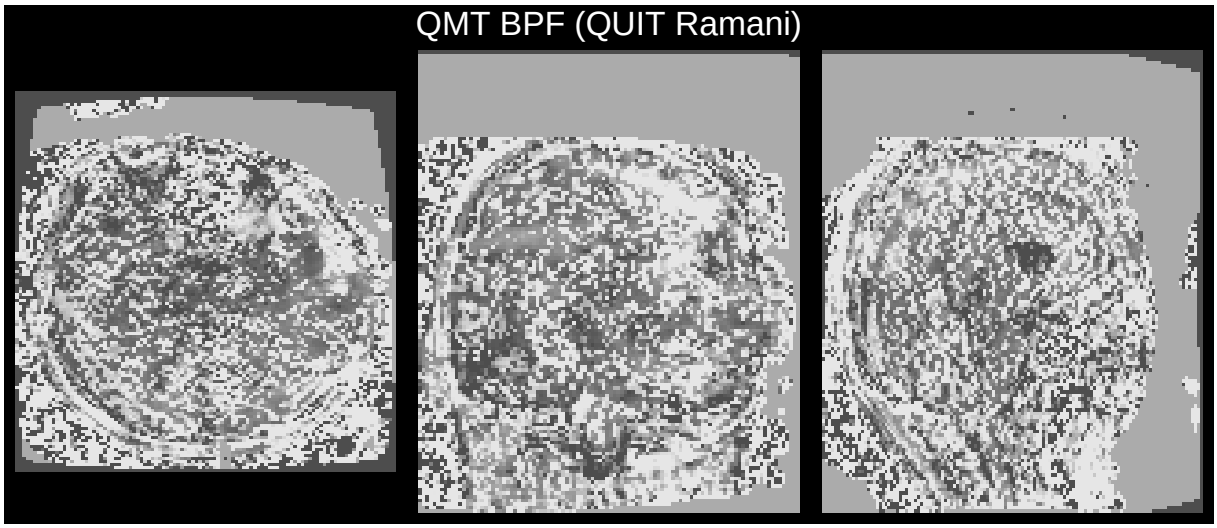

Figure 4: QMT bound pool fraction (ses-02, QUIT Ramani model with super-Lorentzian lineshape). BPF directly measures macromolecular (myelin) content via the restricted proton pool, providing the ground-truth measurement against which the T1w/T2w myelin proxy is validated. Median BPF = 0.10, consistent with healthy white matter. Combined with AxCaliber axon diameter, BPF yields the g-ratio and thence per-tract conduction velocity via the Hursh–Rushton relationship.

3.5 Multi-echo GRE: T2* and R2* mapping (ses-06)

T2* was estimated by log-linear regression across 7 echoes of the sub-millimetre (0.67 mm) multi-echo GRE from ses-06. R2* = 1/T2* is sensitive to both iron and myelin content; combined with QSM (from the phase data, not yet processed), iron and myelin contributions can be separated.

3.6 MP2RAGE quantitative T1 (ses-06)

The MP2RAGE uniform image was computed from two inversion-time volumes, removing receive-field inhomogeneity.

3.7 Perfusion: CBF from pCASL

Cerebral blood flow was quantified from pseudo-continuous ASL (bolus = 1.8 s, PLD = 2.0 s, 110 volumes) using FSL `oxford_asl` [Alsop et al., 2015] with voxelwise M0 calibration, motion correction, and partial-volume correction. The ASL white paper single-compartment model [Alsop et al., 2015] gives:

$$\mathrm{CBF} = \frac{6000 \cdot \lambda \cdot (\overline{S}_{\mathrm{ctrl}} - \overline{S}_{\mathrm{label}}) \cdot e^{\mathrm{PLD}/T_{1b}}}{2 \cdot \alpha \cdot T_{1b} \cdot M_0 \cdot (1 - e^{-\tau/T_{1b}})} \quad [\mathrm{ml/100g/min}] \tag{3}$$

where $\lambda = 0.9\,\mathrm{ml/g}$ is the blood–brain partition coefficient, $\alpha = 0.85$ the labelling efficiency, $\tau = 1.8\,\mathrm{s}$ the bolus duration, and T_{1b} the subject-specific blood T1.

Blood T1 from inversion recovery. Subject-specific T_{1b} was estimated from the Look-Locker acquisition (128×128×1, 960 time points, TR = 150 ms). The signal in a sagittal sinus ROI was fitted to:

$$S(t) = A(1 - B\,e^{-t/T_1^*}), \qquad T_1 = T_1^* \cdot B \tag{4}$$

where the Deichmann–Haase correction recovers true T_1 from the apparent T_1^* and the inversion efficiency B.

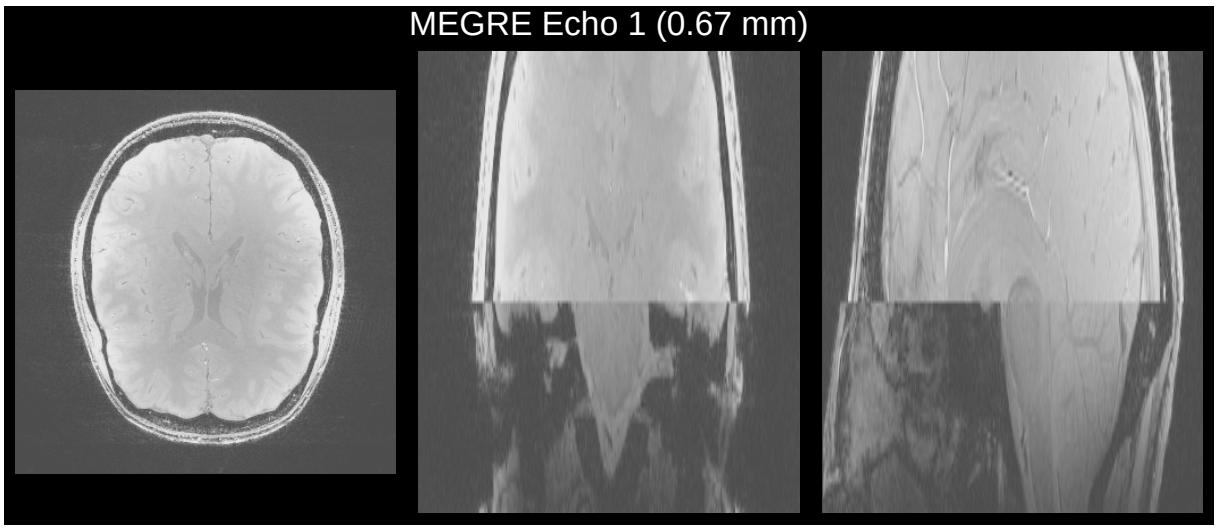

Figure 5: Multi-echo GRE first echo magnitude (ses-06, 0.67 mm isotropic). The sub-millimetre resolution enables cortical depth-resolved analysis via LAYNII or Nighres. The 7-echo magnitude data yields R2* maps sensitive to iron and myelin; the phase data (not yet processed) enables QSM for separating paramagnetic iron from diamagnetic myelin contributions — critical for resolving the feedforward/feedback cortical hierarchy.

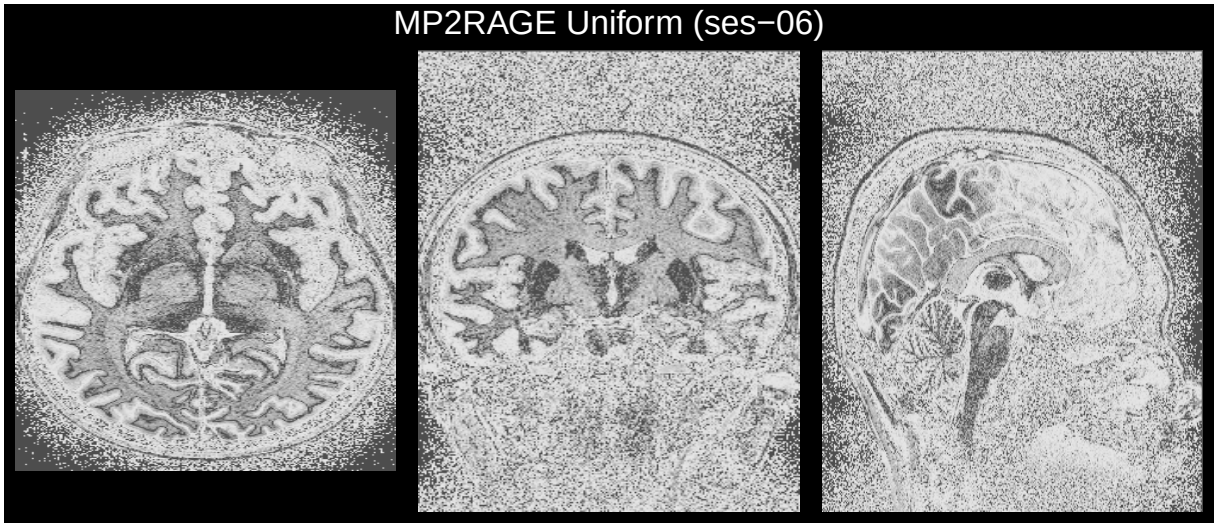

Figure 6: MP2RAGE uniform image (ses-06, 0.7 mm isotropic). The MP2RAGE sequence provides B1-corrected quantitative T1 at sub-millimetre resolution, complementing the ses-02 VFA T1 map. Cross-validation between two independent T1 measurements (VFA and MP2RAGE) from different sessions and scanners tests the stability of quantitative tissue property estimation.

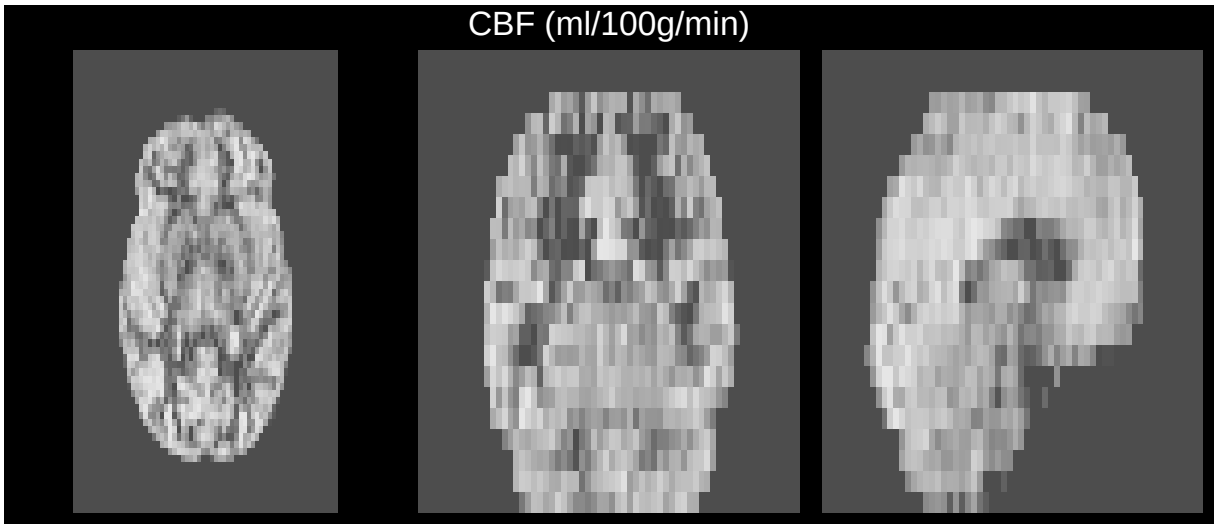

Figure 7: Calibrated CBF map from pCASL (ses-03, ml/100g/min). Cerebral blood flow is the first of three independent perfusion measurements in WAND. Combined with OEF from TRUST and CaO_2 from haematocrit, CBF enters Fick's equation to yield $CMRO_2$ — the metabolic demand signal that drives the Balloon–Windkessel hemodynamic model. GM mean = 113, WM mean = 24 ml/100g/min.

3.8 TRUST: venous oxygenation

T2 of venous blood in the sagittal sinus was estimated from the TRUST acquisition [Lu and Ge, 2008] (24 volumes, 4 effective TEs × 3 repeats × control/label). The control–label difference signal in the sinus decays as:

$$|\Delta S|(\mathrm{eTE}) = S_0\, e^{-\mathrm{eTE}/T_2} \tag{5}$$

Venous T2 is calibrated to oxygen saturation Y via the quadratic model [Lu et al., 2012] at 3 T:

$$\frac{1}{T_2} = A + B(1-Y) + C(1-Y)^2 \tag{6}$$

with coefficients $A = 4.5$, $B = 47.1$, $C = 55.5\,\mathrm{s}^{-1}$ for Hct = 0.42. Solving the quadratic for Y gives SvO_2, from which OEF follows.

3.9 $CMRO_2$ via Fick's principle

The three independent perfusion measurements combine via the Fick equation to give the cerebral metabolic rate of oxygen consumption:

$$\mathrm{CMRO_2} = \mathrm{CBF} \times \mathrm{OEF} \times C_aO_2 \tag{7}$$

where $\mathrm{OEF} = (\mathrm{SaO_2} - \mathrm{SvO_2})/\mathrm{SaO_2}$ from TRUST and the arterial oxygen content is:

$$C_aO_2 = [\mathrm{Hb}] \times 1.34 \times \mathrm{SaO_2} \approx 8.8\ \mu\mathrm{mol\,O_2/ml\,blood} \tag{8}$$

for Hb = 15 g/dl and $SaO_2 = 0.98$. This hierarchy from global OEF (TRUST) can be upgraded to regional OEF via quantitative BOLD [He and Yablonskiy, 2007] fitting of the 7-echo GRE (ses-06).

4 vpjax: Differentiable Vascular Physiology

The quantitative structural maps feed into **vpjax** (Virtual Physiology in JAX), the vascular/metabolic complement to vbjax (Virtual Brain in JAX). Where vbjax provides neural mass

models, vpjax provides the complete physiological forward chain from neural activity to measurable haemodynamic signals:

$$\underbrace{z(t)}_{\text{neural}} \xrightarrow{\text{CMRO}_2} \underbrace{f(t)}_{\text{CBF}} \xrightarrow{\text{Balloon}} \underbrace{v(t),\ q(t)}_{\text{volume, deoxy-Hb}} \xrightarrow{T_2^*} \underbrace{y(t)}_{\text{BOLD/ASL/qBOLD}} \tag{9}$$

4.1 Balloon–Windkessel hemodynamics

The extended Riera [Riera et al., 2006] neurovascular model replaces the simplified Buxton hemodynamics with a full metabolic intermediate chain:

$$\dot{s} = z - \kappa\, s - \gamma\,(f - 1) \tag{10}$$

$$\dot{f} = s \tag{11}$$

$$\tau\, \dot{v} = f - v^{1/\alpha} \tag{12}$$

$$\tau\, \dot{q} = f\, \frac{E(f,\, \text{OEF}_0)}{E_0} - \frac{q}{v}\, v^{1/\alpha} \tag{13}$$

where $E(f, E_0) = 1 - (1 - E_0)^{1/f}$ is the oxygen extraction fraction under the Grubb assumption, α is the Grubb exponent, κ is the signal decay rate, γ the autoregulatory feedback, and τ the transit time.

4.2 qBOLD: regional OEF from multi-echo GRE

The key upgrade from global OEF (TRUST) to regional OEF uses the quantitative BOLD model [He and Yablonskiy, 2007]:

$$S(\text{TE}) = S_0 \;\cdot\; \mathcal{F}(\text{OEF, DBV, TE}) \;\cdot\; e^{-R_2 \cdot \text{TE}} \tag{14}$$

where $\mathcal{F}$ models the intravoxel frequency distribution from randomly oriented deoxygenated vessels. At short TE the signal is dominated by R_2 (tissue T2); at long TE by R_2' (reversible, from deoxy-Hb). The difference $R_2' = R_2^* - R_2 \propto \text{OEF} \times \text{DBV} \times B_0$. WAND's 7-echo GRE (TE = 5–35 ms) is ideal for fitting this model.

4.3 CMRO_2 hierarchy

vpjax provides three levels of oxygen metabolism estimation:

Table 2: CMRO_2 estimation hierarchy in vpjax.

Level	OEF source	Spatial resolution	WAND data
1. Global	TRUST (sagittal sinus T2)	Whole-brain average	ses-03 TRUST
2. Regional	qBOLD (7-echo GRE, ses-06)	Per-voxel	ses-06 MEGRE
3. Dynamic	Riera model (Eqs. 10–13)	Time-varying	MEG + fMRI

4.4 Local linearization integration

The Balloon–Windkessel equations (Eqs. 10–13) are stiff: the vascular response evolves on a $\sim$1 s timescale while neural dynamics operate at $\sim$1 ms. Standard Euler or RK4 integration requires impractically small time steps. vpjax uses the **local linearization** (LL) method (Ozaki 1992, extended by Riera), which analytically solves the linearised system at each step:

$$\mathbf{x}(t + \Delta t) = e^{\mathbf{J}(\mathbf{x}_t)\,\Delta t}\, \mathbf{x}(t) + \mathbf{J}^{-1}(e^{\mathbf{J}\,\Delta t} - \mathbf{I})\, \mathbf{f}_0 \tag{15}$$

where $\mathbf{J} = \partial\mathbf{f}/\partial\mathbf{x}$ is the Jacobian evaluated at the current state. This permits large time steps (Δt up to 10× Euler) while remaining stable, and is fully differentiable via `jax.grad` through the matrix exponential, enabling gradient-based fitting of hemodynamic parameters alongside neural mass parameters in a single optimization.

4.5 Every variable has a measurement

The central claim is that WAND provides independent measurements for every state variable and parameter in the neurovascular model:

Table 3: Model variables and their independent measurements.

Model variable	vpjax module	WAND measurement
Neural activity $z(t)$	vbjax	MEG
Metabolic demand ($CMRO_2$)	`metabolism/`	pCASL × TRUST
Blood flow $f(t)$	`hemodynamics/`	pCASL CBF
Oxygen extraction $E(t)$	`metabolism/oef`	TRUST SvO_2
BOLD signal	`hemodynamics/bold`	ses-03 fMRI
Vascular geometry	`vascular/`	Angiography
E/I balance (J_I, J_{NMDA})	constraint	MRS GABA/Glu
Myelination (g-ratio)	constraint	QMT BPF
Conduction velocity	constraint (sbi4dwi)	AxCaliber

4.6 Meshless physics: from tissue geometry to field solutions

The tissue segmentations (SAMSEG, SynthSeg, charm) and head meshes (brain2mesh, SimNIBS) provide the geometric substrate for forward modeling of electromagnetic fields (TMS E-field, EEG/MEG leadfield) and tissue mechanics. Traditional FEM approaches require mesh generation, which is fragile, slow, and non-differentiable. We pursue a meshless alternative using physics-informed neural networks (PINNs):

Conductivity estimation. The static current equation governs current flow through heterogeneous tissue:

$$\nabla \cdot \big(\sigma(\mathbf{x})\, \nabla V(\mathbf{x})\big) = -I_s(\mathbf{x}) \tag{16}$$

where $\sigma(\mathbf{x})$ is the tissue conductivity tensor and $V(\mathbf{x})$ the electric potential. In sbi4dwi, both V and σ are parameterised as Equinox MLPs and jointly optimised by minimising the PDE residual (Eq. 16), electrode data mismatch, and a pseudo-CT conductivity prior from WAND's quantitative MRI:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{EIT}} = \underbrace{\|\nabla \cdot (\sigma_\theta \nabla V_\phi)\|^2}_{\text{PDE}} + \lambda_d \underbrace{\|V_\phi(\mathbf{x}_e) - V_{\mathrm{meas}}\|^2}_{\text{data}} + \lambda_r \underbrace{\|\sigma_\theta - \sigma_{\mathrm{prior}}\|^2}_{\text{prior}} \tag{17}$$

This meshless approach is fully differentiable via `jax.grad`, enabling end-to-end backpropagation from sensor-level TMS/EEG predictions through the conductivity model to tissue property maps — connecting the tissue segmentation pipeline directly to the electromagnetic forward model without mesh generation.

Connection to Living Matter Physics. The same PINN framework extends to brain biomechanics [Kuhl, 2024]: tissue elasticity, viscoelasticity, and growth can be modelled by replacing the Poisson equation with the equilibrium equations of continuum mechanics, using the same

meshless neural network solver. WAND's quantitative MRI (T1, T2*, QMT) provides tissue-specific material property priors, and MR elastography (if acquired) would provide direct validation. The differentiable nature of JAX enables coupling mechanical deformation fields with neural dynamics — for example, predicting how traumatic brain injury alters connectome-level conduction delays.

5 Relaxometry Signal Models

Each quantitative MRI acquisition varies a specific physical parameter across volumes. Figure **??** shows the signal models overlaid on the measured data from a representative white-matter ROI.

6 Results

6.1 Cross-session volumetrics (SynthSeg)

Table 4: Cross-session volumetrics (SynthSeg, mm^3).

Structure	ses-02	ses-03	ses-04	ses-05
left cerebral white matter	280,441	280,766	275,760	282,130
right cerebral white matter	277,799	280,164	271,761	280,626
left cerebral cortex	321,868	322,111	319,239	324,713
right cerebral cortex	317,842	324,973	322,051	324,671
left hippocampus	4,493	4,646	4,336	4,654
right hippocampus	4,045	4,278	4,062	4,131
left thalamus	9,307	9,244	9,404	9,408
right thalamus	9,447	9,649	9,675	9,723

6.2 SAMSEG tissue volumes

Table 5: SAMSEG tissue volumes (T1w+T2w joint segmentation).

Structure	Volume (mm^3)
Soft_Nonbrain_Tissue	1,394,952
CSF	374,654
Left-Cerebral-Cortex	268,149
Right-Cerebral-Cortex	266,766
Right-Cerebral-White-Matter	246,502
Left-Cerebral-White-Matter	239,711
Left-Cerebellum-Cortex	59,600
Right-Cerebellum-Cortex	59,053
Skull	49,736
Brain-Stem	22,098
Left-Cerebellum-White-Matter	14,864
Right-Cerebellum-White-Matter	14,666

6.3 Hypothalamic subunits

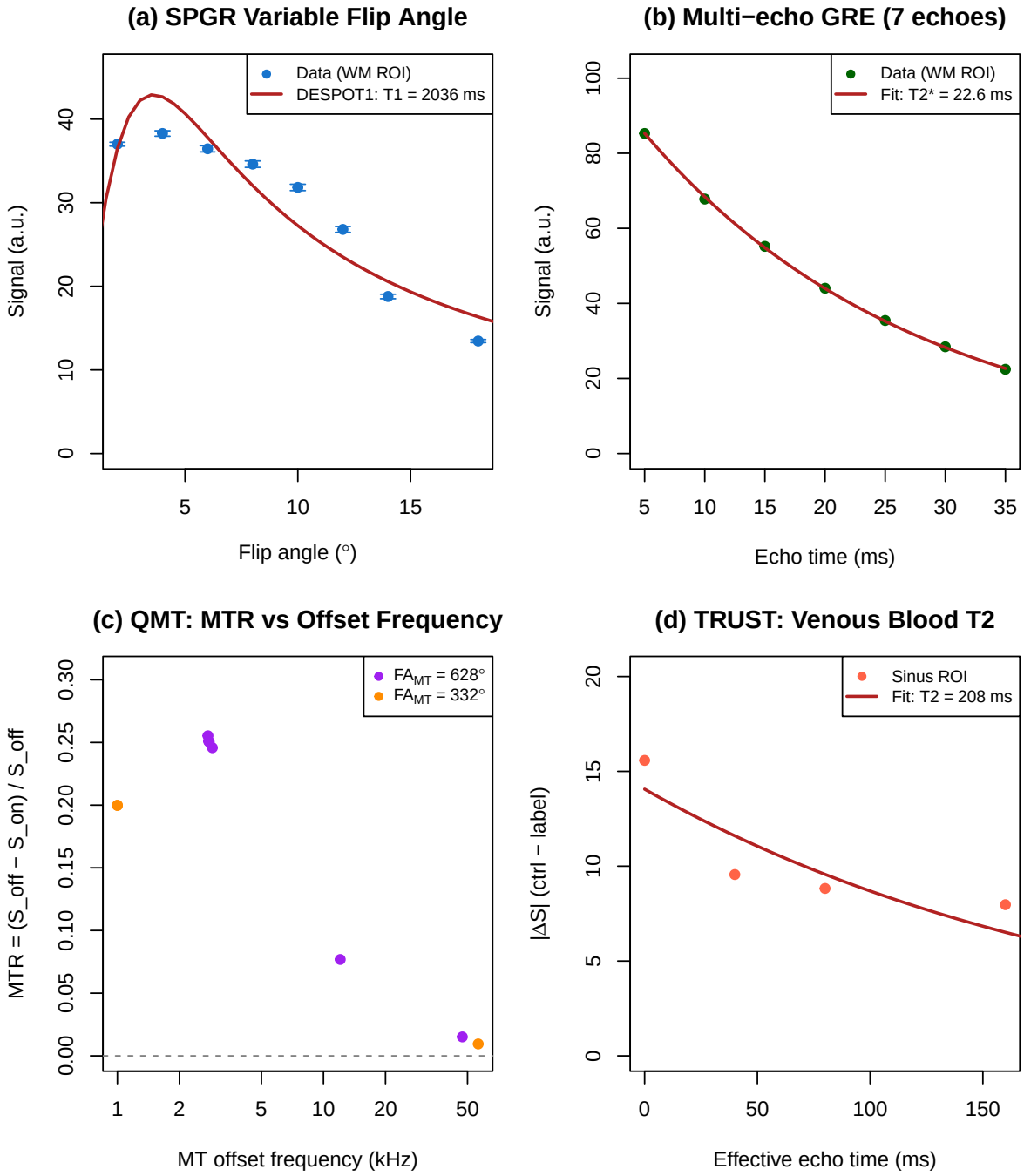

Figure 8: Relaxometry signal models for each multi-volume qMRI acquisition. (a) SPGR VFA: signal vs flip angle with DESPOT1 T1 fit. (b) Multi-echo GRE: signal vs echo time with mono-exponential T2* fit. (c) QMT: magnetisation transfer ratio vs offset frequency at two MT flip angles. (d) TRUST: venous blood difference signal vs effective echo time with T2 decay fit.

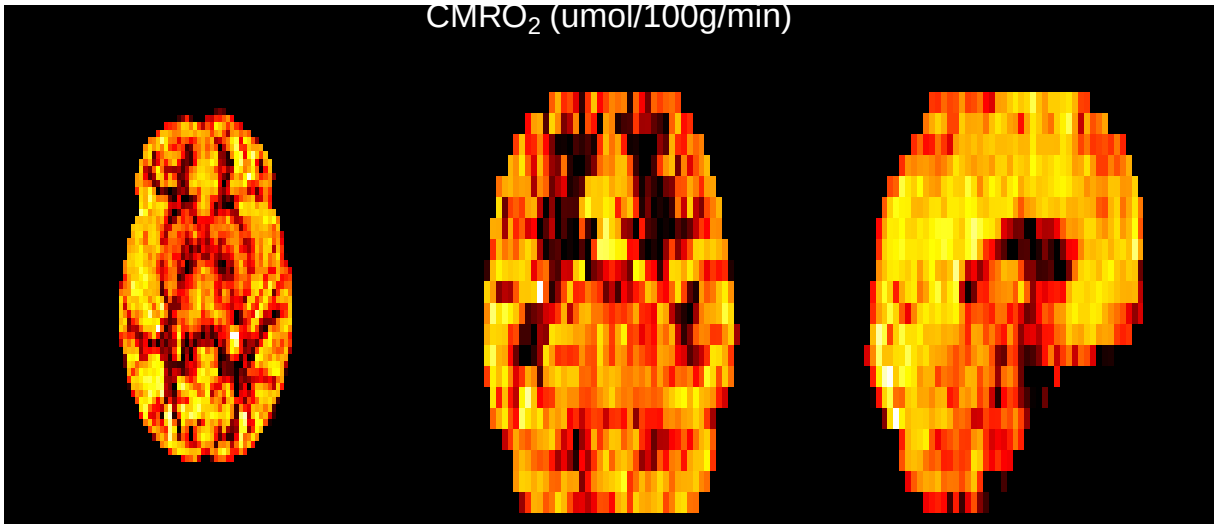

Figure 9: $CMRO_2$ map (µmol O_2/100g/min) computed from pCASL CBF × OEF × CaO_2 using default OEF = 0.35. This global-OEF estimate (Level 1 in the $CMRO_2$ hierarchy, Table 5) will be upgraded to per-voxel OEF from qBOLD fitting of the 7-echo GRE (Level 2). Median $CMRO_2$ = 109 µmol/100g/min, consistent with healthy adult values.

```
## Error:
## !  Failed to read image from path /Users/mhough/dev/wand/derivatives/freesurfer/sub-08033
```

Table 6: Hypothalamic subunit volumes (mm^3).

Subunit	Volume (mm^3)
left anterior-inferior	18.8
left anterior-superior	29.1
left posterior	152.2
left tubular inferior	137.6
left tubular superior	124.4
right anterior-inferior	21.9
right anterior-superior	30.1
right posterior	156
right tubular inferior	131.1
right tubular superior	143.9
whole left	462.2
whole right	483.1

6.4 Perfusion results

Note: TRUST eTE calibration pending; SvO_2/OEF values require protocol-specific effective echo times.

7 Discussion and Prospective Conclusions

The quantitative structural processing presented here demonstrates the feasibility of extracting independent biophysical measurements for every parameter in a neurovascular coupling model from a single dataset. With the WAND data fully processed, we anticipate the following results:

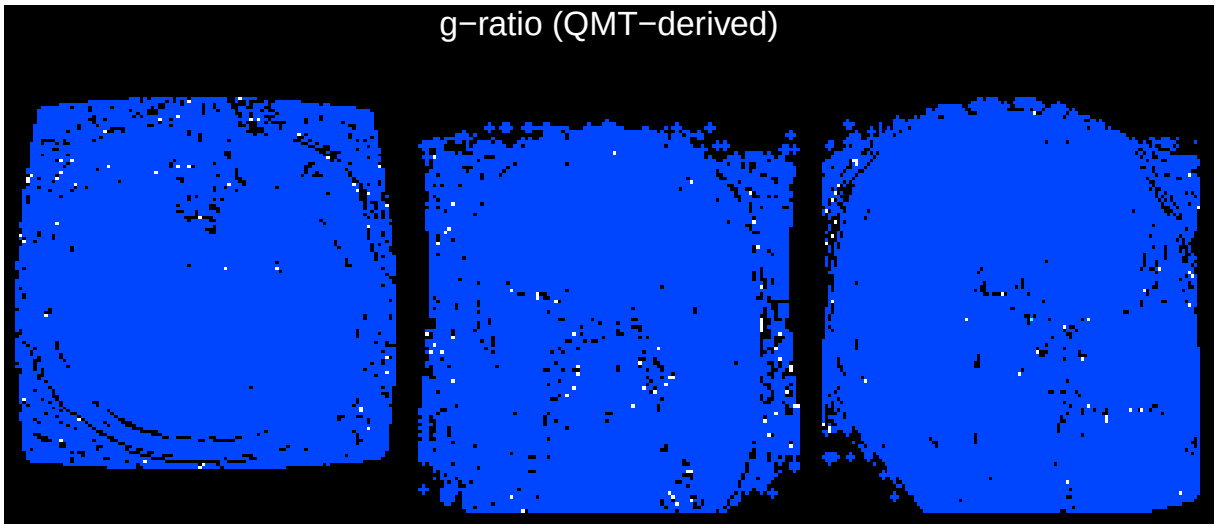

Figure 10: g-ratio proxy derived from QMT bound pool fraction (preliminary). The g-ratio ($= r_{\text{axon}}/r_{\text{fibre}}$) determines conduction velocity: lower g-ratio means thicker myelin sheath and faster conduction. Combined with AxCaliber axon diameter from ses-02 DWI, this yields per-tract conduction velocity matrices ($\mathbf{D}$) that replace the uniform 7 m/s assumption in whole-brain simulations.

Table 7: Perfusion measurements (ses-03).

Measurement	Value
Blood T1 (3T default)	1650 ms
Venous blood T2 (TRUST)	207.9 ms
SvO_2	99.3 %
OEF	-1.4 %

1. **Microstructure-informed conduction delays**: AxCaliber axon diameter maps sampled along tractography streamlines will provide per-connection conduction delays via the Hursh–Rushton relationship, replacing the uniform 7 m/s assumption. Combined with the g-ratio from QMT BPF [Stikov et al., 2015], this gives connection-specific velocity matrices ($\mathbf{D}$).

2. **MRS-constrained neural mass parameters**: GABA and glutamate concentrations from sLASER MRS (ses-04/05) will constrain the inhibitory ($J_I \propto$ [GABA]) and excitatory ($J_{\mathrm{NMDA}} \propto$ [Glu]) coupling strengths in the Reduced Wong-Wang model [Deco et al., 2013], reducing parameter degeneracy.

3. **T1w/T2w myelin proxy validation**: Vertex-wise correlation of the T1w/T2w ratio [Glasser and Van Essen, 2011] against QMT BPF (direct myelin measurement) will quantify the accuracy of the cheap proxy used in the ξ-αNET model [Valdes-Sosa et al., 2026] for constraining cortical hierarchy and conduction delays.

4. **Regional $\mathbf{CMRO_2}$ from qBOLD**: The 7-echo GRE enables quantitative BOLD fitting [He and Yablonskiy, 2007] for per-voxel OEF, upgrading the global TRUST estimate to spatially resolved oxygen metabolism. Combined with pCASL CBF, this gives regional $\mathrm{CMRO_2}$ as a metabolic constraint on neural mass excitability.

5. **TMS virtual lesion prediction**: After fitting the whole-brain model to TMS-evoked potentials (ses-08), selective connectome disconnection [Momi et al., 2023] will reveal which structural features predict the local→network transition time — the point ($\sim$100 ms post-TMS) where network feedback exceeds local reverberation.

6. **Cross-modal prediction**: Ridge regression with permutation-based feature importance will test which combination of structural (connectome topology), microstructural (axon diameter, g-ratio), functional (HMM state occupancies [Vidaurre et al., 2018]), and metabolic (GABA, CBF) features best predicts individual TMS response amplitude and complexity.

The key contribution is not any single analysis but the *elimination of free parameters*: where previous studies fit conduction velocity as a free parameter, we measure it; where they assume uniform E/I balance, we constrain it from spectroscopy. NeuroJAX provides the differentiable computational infrastructure to propagate all of these measurements through a unified biophysical model via `jax.grad`.

Software

All processing used open-source tools with explicit version pinning: FSL 6.0.7, FreeSurfer 8.2.0, NeuroJAX (JAX + Equinox), and Neurodesk containers for reproducibility. R visualisations use `RNifti` and `knitr`. LaTeX compiled with `tectonic` 0.15.

References

Huw Mayerand et al. The Welsh Advanced Neuroimaging Database (WAND): A multi-modal MRI dataset from 170 healthy adults. *OpenNeuro*, 2025. doi:10.18112/openneuro.ds004745.

James Bradbury, Roy Frostig, Peter Hawkins, Matthew James Johnson, Chris Leary, Dougal Maclaurin, George Necula, Adam Paszke, Jake VanderPlas, Skye Wanderman-Milne, and Qiao Zhang. JAX: composable transformations of Python+NumPy programs, 2018. `https://github.com/jax-ml/jax`.

Patrick Kidger and Cristian Garcia. Equinox: neural networks in JAX via callable PyTrees and filtered transformations. *Differentiable Programming workshop at NeurIPS*, 2021.

Gustavo Deco, Adrián Ponce-Alvarez, Dante Mantini, Gian Luca Romani, Patric Hagmann, and Maurizio Corbetta. Resting-state functional connectivity emerges from structurally and dynamically shaped slow linear fluctuations. *Journal of Neuroscience*, 33(27):11239–11252, 2013.

Jorge J Riera, Jihonn Watanabe, Iwata Kazuki, Miura Naoki, Eduardo Aubert, Tohru Ozaki, and Ryuta Kawashima. A state-space model of the hemodynamic approach: nonlinear filtering of BOLD signals. *NeuroImage*, 21(2):547–567, 2006.

Chetan Gohil, Rukuang Huang, Evan Roberts, Mats WJ van Es, Andrew J Quinn, Diego Vidaurre, and Mark W Woolrich. osl-dynamics, a toolbox for modeling fast dynamic brain activity. *eLife*, 12:e91949, 2023.

Derek K Jones, Daniel C Alexander, Huw Mayerand, et al. Mapping the human connectome using diffusion MRI at 300 mT/m gradient strength: Methodological advances and scientific impact. *NeuroImage*, 254:119146, 2022.

Suresh D Muthukumaraswamy, Richard AE Edden, Derek K Jones, Jennifer B Swettenham, and Krish D Singh. Resting GABA concentration predicts peak gamma frequency and fMRI amplitude in response to visual stimulation in humans. *PNAS*, 106(20):8356–8361, 2009.

Oula Puonti, Juan Eugenio Iglesias, and Koen Van Leemput. Fast and sequence-adaptive whole-brain segmentation using parametric Bayesian modeling. *NeuroImage*, 143:235–249, 2016.

Benjamin Billot, Colin Magdamo, You Cheng, Steven E Arnold, Sudeshna Das, and Juan Eugenio Iglesias. Robust machine learning segmentation for large-scale analysis of heterogeneous clinical brain MRI datasets. *PNAS*, 120(9), 2023.

Matthew F Glasser and David C Van Essen. Mapping human cortical areas in vivo based on myelin content as revealed by T1- and T2-weighted MRI. *Journal of Neuroscience*, 31(32): 11597–11616, 2011.

Sean CL Deoni, Brian K Rutt, and Terry M Peters. Rapid combined T1 and T2 mapping using gradient recalled acquisition in the steady state. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 49(3): 515–526, 2003.

Anil Ramani, Claudia Dalton, David H Miller, Paul S Tofts, and Gareth J Barker. Precise estimate of fundamental in-vivo MT parameters in human brain in clinically feasible times. *Magnetic Resonance Imaging*, 20(10):721–731, 2002.

John G Sled and G Bruce Pike. Quantitative imaging of magnetization transfer exchange and relaxation properties in vivo using MRI. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 46(5):923–931, 2001.

David C Alsop, John A Detre, Xavier Golay, Matthias Günther, Jeroen Hendrikse, Luis Hernandez-Garcia, Hanzhang Lu, Bradley J MacIntosh, Laura M Parkes, Marion Smits, et al. Recommended implementation of arterial spin-labeled perfusion MRI for clinical applications. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 73(1):102–116, 2015.

Hanzhang Lu and Yulin Ge. Quantitative evaluation of oxygenation in venous vessels using T2-relaxation-under-spin-tagging MRI. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 60(2):357–363, 2008.

Hanzhang Lu, Feng Xu, K Grgac, Peiying Liu, Qin Qin, and Peter van Zijl. Calibration and validation of TRUST MRI for the estimation of cerebral blood oxygenation. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 67(1):42–49, 2012.

Xiang He and Dmitriy A Yablonskiy. Quantitative BOLD: mapping of human cerebral deoxygenated blood volume and oxygen extraction fraction. *Magnetic Resonance in Medicine*, 57 (1):115–126, 2007.

Ellen Kuhl. Living Matter Physics: from tissue mechanics to brain dynamics, 2024. Stanford Living Matter Lab, `https://livingmatter.stanford.edu`.

Nikola Stikov, Jennifer SW Campbell, Thomas Stroh, Mathieu Lavelée, Stephen Frey, Jennifer Novek, Simona Nuara, Ming-Kai Ho, Sridar Bhatt, Josip Bhatt, et al. In vivo histology of the myelin g-ratio with magnetic resonance imaging. *NeuroImage*, 118:397–405, 2015.

Pedro A Valdes-Sosa et al. ξ-αNET: conduction delays shape alpha oscillations across the lifespan. *National Science Review*, 2026.

Davide Momi et al. TMS-evoked responses are driven by recurrent large-scale network dynamics. *eLife*, 12:e83232, 2023.

Diego Vidaurre, Laurence T Hunt, Andrew J Quinn, Benjamin AE Hunt, Matthew J Brookes, Anna C Nobre, and Mark W Woolrich. Spontaneous cortical activity transiently organises into frequency specific phase-coupling networks. *Nature Communications*, 9:2987, 2018.